

D601

Data Storytelling for Varied Audiences

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

An analyst will present a supply-chain finding to the plant's maintenance engineers and, separately, to the CFO next week. The analysis used 18 months of sensor logs and took five weeks. For the CFO, what should the emphasis be?

- A. Financial impact and the recommended decision, with technical detail in an appendix.
- B. Sensor-level findings and the diagnostic method.
- C. The five weeks of effort behind the analysis.
- D. The same deck for both audiences, to keep the message consistent.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A regional bank's analyst found that branch wait times above 12 minutes predict account closures. She has 5 minutes with the executive committee, which meets in a newly renovated room. How should she open?

- A. Walk through data preparation in the order she did it.
- B. Show the data dictionary so they trust the fields.
- C. State the main finding and recommendation first, then support it.
- D. Open with a remark about the renovated room.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which sequence follows a classic data-story arc?

- A. Resolution → conflict → context
- B. Context → conflict or insight → resolution and call to action
- C. Any order works if the charts are accurate
- D. Context → data tables → end

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A utility's customer team wants to show monthly outage minutes over the past 36 months for its 3 service regions. The team's slide template uses a dark theme. Which chart fits?

- A. A pie chart of total outage minutes by region
- B. A line chart with one line per region
- C. A scatter plot of region vs. outage minutes
- D. A bar chart of each region's 36-month total

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which question is a pie chart best suited to answer?

- A. Is ad spend related to sales across 200 stores?
- B. Any comparison, since pie charts always show proportions clearly
- C. What share of this year's sales came from each of three channels?
- D. How did sales change over 24 months?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A dashboard at a 700-bed hospital shows 12 department lines in 12 bright colors. The key point is that the emergency department line rose sharply. The design was approved by the IT steering committee. Which change best directs attention?

- A. Add a detailed legend for all 12 departments.
- B. Gray out the other lines and show the emergency line in one strong color with a direct label.
- C. Add 3D effects and more colors so each line stands out.
- D. Leave it as is, since the committee approved it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A nonprofit's annual report, laid out by a volunteer graphic artist, shows donor retention of 71% vs. 68% as bars on a y-axis that starts at 65%. The report will be mailed to 5,000 donors. What is the main problem?

- A. Bar axes should start near the smallest value to show detail.
- B. It should be a pie chart.
- C. The volunteer's color choices.
- D. The truncated axis makes a 3-point gap look like the first bar is twice the second.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A bar chart's y-axis starts at 90. Bar A shows 95 and bar B shows 100. How much taller does B look than A, and how different are the values really?

- A.** Truncated axes never change how bars look.
- B.** B looks 10 times as tall.
- C.** B looks about 5% taller, matching the values.
- D.** B looks twice as tall, but its value is only about 5% higher.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A sales operations manager needs to monitor pipeline by region and rep every day and drill into problems as they appear. A consultant billed 40 hours gathering the requirements. Which deliverable fits?

- A.** A 40-page written report
- B.** A one-time static slide story
- C.** A printed monthly report
- D.** An interactive dashboard with filters by region and rep

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A one-time board presentation must persuade directors to approve a single budget change. Which deliverable fits best?

- A.** A focused narrative with one or two clear charts and a specific ask
- B.** Dashboards are always better than slides.
- C.** A raw data export for directors to analyze
- D.** An interactive dashboard with 20 filters

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A public-health department’s map marks improving counties green and worsening counties red, with no other cue. The map will be posted on the department’s website, which was redesigned in 2024. What fix best improves accessibility?

- A. Roll back the 2024 website redesign.
- B. Make the red and green brighter.
- C. Use a colorblind-safe palette plus labels or patterns, and add alt text.
- D. Remove color entirely; charts must always be grayscale.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

An analyst’s final slide on warehouse picking errors (down from 4.1% to 2.7% after a pilot at 2 of 9 sites) says only “Questions?” The pilot sites are in Nevada. What would make the ending stronger?

- A. A specific ask: approve rollout to the remaining 7 sites by a set date, with the expected error reduction.
- B. A “Thank you” slide.
- C. A note about Nevada’s climate.
- D. More detail on how the pilot was run.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

An analyst will present a supply-chain finding to the plant's maintenance engineers and, separately, to the CFO next week. ~~The analysis used 18 months of sensor logs and took five weeks.~~ For the CFO, what should the emphasis be?

Target word: emphasis for the finance executive **Decides:** The CFO decides on money and risk, not on sensor mechanics.

A	Correct	Leads with what this audience needs to act.
B	Adjacent category	Suits the engineers, not the CFO.
C	Camouflage	Effort does not help the CFO decide.
D	Dropped element	Drops audience tailoring entirely.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A regional bank's analyst found that branch wait times above 12 minutes predict account closures. She has 5 minutes with the executive committee, ~~which meets in a newly renovated room.~~ How should she open?

Target word: opening for executives **Decides:** Five minutes with decision makers.

A	Inverted operation	Process first buries the message.
B	Adjacent category	Technical support material, not an opener.
C	Correct	Busy decision makers need the message up front.
D	Camouflage	The room does not shape the message.

3. Answer B Concept 2 · transfer

Which sequence follows a classic data-story arc?

Target word: order of story parts **Decides:** Setup, then tension, then resolution.

A	Inverted operation	Reverses the arc; the resolution has nothing to resolve.
B	Correct	The standard narrative arc applied to data.
C	Absolute language	Accuracy does not replace structure.
D	Dropped element	No tension and no resolution.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A utility's customer team wants to show monthly outage minutes over the past 36 months for its 3 service regions. ~~The team's slide template uses a dark theme.~~ Which chart fits?

Target word: chart for a trend by group **Decides:** Change over time for a few groups.

A	Confusion set	Shows share of a total and loses the time trend.
B	Correct	Lines show change over time and allow comparison.
C	Adjacent category	Scatter is for two numeric variables, not a time series.
D	Dropped element	Collapses the months, so no trend.

5. Answer C Concept 3 · transfer

Which question is a pie chart best suited to answer?

Target word: reverse: from chart to question **Decides:** Pie charts show a few parts of one whole.

A	Confusion set	A relationship calls for a scatter plot.
B	Absolute language	Pies are hard to read beyond a few slices.
C	Correct	A few parts that sum to one whole.
D	Adjacent category	A time trend calls for a line chart.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A dashboard ~~at a 700-bed hospital~~ shows 12 department lines in 12 bright colors. The key point is that the emergency department line rose sharply. ~~The design was approved by the IT steering committee.~~ Which change best directs attention?

Target word: design fix to highlight the point **Decides:** One series matters; eleven are context.

A	Adjacent category	Helps lookup but does not point to the key line.
B	Correct	Contrast draws the eye to the single message.
C	Inverted operation	More emphasis everywhere means emphasis nowhere.
D	Camouflage	Approval history does not decide design quality.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A nonprofit's annual report, ~~laid out by a volunteer graphic artist,~~ shows donor retention of 71% vs. 68% as bars on a y-axis that starts at 65%. ~~The report will be mailed to 5,000 donors.~~ What is the main problem?

Target word: chart integrity issue **Decides:** Bars on a truncated axis.

A	Inverted operation	That is the cause of the distortion; bars must start at zero.
B	Confusion set	Two retention rates are not parts of one whole.
C	Camouflage	Who designed it does not decide the distortion.
D	Correct	Visible heights are 6 and 3, so bars exaggerate a small difference.

8. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

A bar chart's y-axis starts at 90. Bar A shows 95 and bar B shows 100. How much taller does B look than A, and how different are the values really?

Target word: visual vs. real difference **Decides:** Visible heights are 5 and 10.

A	Absolute language	Bar length encodes value from the baseline.
B	Wrong stem number	Uses the visible height of B alone.
C	Dropped element	Ignores that the axis starts at 90.
D	Correct	$(100 - 90) / (95 - 90) = 2$; $100 / 95 \approx 1.05$.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A sales operations manager needs to monitor pipeline by region and rep every day and drill into problems as they appear. ~~A consultant billed 40 hours gathering the requirements.~~ Which deliverable fits?

Target word: deliverable type **Decides:** Ongoing monitoring with drill-down.

A	Wrong stem number	Echoes the 40 hours; length does not meet the need.
B	Adjacent category	Explanatory; it cannot be refreshed or explored daily.
C	Confusion set	Too slow for daily monitoring and cannot drill down.
D	Correct	Supports daily monitoring and exploration.

10. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

A one-time board presentation must persuade directors to approve a single budget change. Which deliverable fits best?

Target word: reverse: explanatory case **Decides:** One decision, one audience, one time.

A	Correct	Explanatory storytelling suits a single persuasive decision.
B	Absolute language	The right format depends on the purpose.
C	Dropped element	Drops the analysis and the message.
D	Inverted operation	Built for exploration, not persuasion.

11. Answer C Concept 7

A public-health department's map marks improving counties green and worsening counties red, with no other cue. The map will be posted on the department's website, ~~which was redesigned in 2024.~~ What fix best improves accessibility?

Target word: accessibility fix **Decides:** Meaning carried by red vs. green alone.

A	Camouflage	The site redesign does not cause the chart problem.
B	Dropped element	Brightness does not fix red-green confusion.
C	Correct	Redundant cues work for everyone, including readers with color vision deficiency.
D	Absolute language	Color is fine when it is not the only cue.

12. Answer A Concept 8

An analyst's final slide on warehouse picking errors (down from 4.1% to 2.7% after a pilot at 2 of 9 sites) says only "Questions?" ~~The pilot sites are in Nevada.~~ What would make the ending stronger?

Target word: strong close **Decides:** The story asks for nothing.

A	Correct	Names who acts, what, when, and the payoff.
B	Dropped element	Still no call to action.
C	Camouflage	Location does not drive the decision.
D	Adjacent category	Support material, not a close.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	7	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Tailor to the audience	Match depth, vocabulary, and emphasis to what each audience must decide or do; the same finding is told differently to executives and to technical teams.	One deck for everyone, or leading with effort and method.	Two named audiences with different roles.
2	Story structure and the lead	A data story moves from context to conflict (the insight) to resolution (the action); for busy decision makers, state the main message first.	Walking through the analysis in the order it was done.	Limited time with a decision maker, or a question about sequence.
3	Chart choice	Line for change over time, bar for comparing categories, scatter for relationships, pie only for a few parts of one whole.	Using pie or stacked totals for trends, or any chart the template offers.	“Over the past 36 months,” “compare,” “share of.”
4	Declutter and direct attention	Use preattentive cues (one strong color, direct labels) to highlight the key series and push everything else to the background.	Adding more colors, legends, or effects to make every series visible.	Many series on one chart but one point to make.
5	Misleading axes	Bar charts must start at zero; a truncated axis inflates visible differences.	Starting the axis near the data “to show detail” on bars.	Bars whose axis starts well above zero.
6	Exploratory vs. explanatory deliverables	Interactive dashboards suit ongoing monitoring and exploration; a focused, static narrative suits a one-time persuasive decision.	Giving a board a filter-heavy dashboard or an operations team a one-off slide.	“Monitor daily” and “drill in” vs. “approve one decision.”
7	Accessible visuals	Do not rely on color alone; use colorblind-safe palettes plus redundant cues (labels, shapes, patterns) and text or audio alternatives.	Fixing red-green charts by making colors brighter.	Meaning carried only by red vs. green.
8	End with a call to action	A data story closes with a specific ask: who should do what, by when, and the expected impact.	Ending with “Questions?” or more supporting detail.	A final slide that states results but asks for nothing.

Course scope (public description): Data Storytelling for Varied Audiences focuses on communicating observations and patterns to diverse stakeholders, a key aspect of the data analytics life cycle. This course helps learners gain communication and storytelling skills in order to motivate change and answer business problems. It also covers data visualizations, audio representations, interactive dashboards, interpersonal communication, and presentation skills. There is no pre-requisite for this course.